

LittleReads

Goodnight, Little Explorer

Bedtime Stories

Ages 5–7

by LittleReads Editorial Team

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The East was setting before him, his grandiose, his dyed blades of gold and the edge of the garden and looked out at the world.

Chapter 1: The Chocolate River

As the last light of day faded, the garden began to change. The flowers grew taller. The trees stretched wider. And a river appeared where there had been none before — a river of warm, flowing chocolate.

Little Explorer stepped onto the bank and dipped her toe in. It was smooth and sweet.

She found a leaf boat and climbed in. The chocolate river carried her gently downstream, past chocolate banks lined with marshmallow flowers and candy cane trees.

A family of frogs sat on a lily pad, croaking lullabies. "Ribbit, ribbit, rest your head. The day is done, it is time for bed."

Little Explorer smiled and let the river carry her on.

Chapter 2: The Pillow Mountain

The chocolate river led her to the foot of a tall mountain. But this was no ordinary mountain — it was made entirely of soft, fluffy pillows.

Little Explorer climbed. Each step was soft and warm, like sinking into a cloud.

Halfway up, she met a cloud rabbit who was napping on a pillow ledge.

"Where are you going?" asked the rabbit sleepily.

"To the top of Pillow Mountain!"

"Why?"

"To see the view before bed."

The rabbit yawned. "The best view is right here, where it is warm and soft. Why not rest a while?"

Little Explorer sat beside the rabbit for a moment, feeling the softness of the mountain beneath her.

"Maybe just a moment," she said.

Chapter 3: The Firefly Forest

When Little Explorer continued her climb, she reached the top of the mountain and stepped into a magical forest.

Every tree was filled with fireflies — hundreds of them — glowing soft gold and green.

They danced through the air like living stars, leaving trails of gentle light.

Little Explorer walked among them, her hands outstretched, letting the light dance around her fingers.

An old owl sat in the highest branch of the tallest tree.

"Beautiful, is it not?" said the owl.

"It is the most beautiful thing I have ever seen," said Little Explorer.

"The fireflies only come out at night," said the owl. "They save their light for when the world is dark, to remind everyone that there is beauty even in the quiet moments."

Little Explorer watched the fireflies dance and felt her eyelids growing heavy.

Chapter 4: The Star Garden

Beyond the forest, Little Explorer found a garden — but not a garden of flowers. This was a garden of stars.

They grew from the ground like silver tulips, each one glowing with a soft, warm light.

She reached out and touched one. It was warm, like holding a tiny sun.

"These are baby stars," said a voice. It was the friendly owl, who had flown silently behind her.

"Where do they come from?"

"From dreams," said the owl. "Every time a child falls asleep thinking happy thoughts, a star is born. The more you dream, the more stars grow."

Little Explorer picked a small star and held it close. It made her feel warm and safe.

"I will dream happy dreams tonight," she said.

"Then the garden will grow," said the owl.

Chapter 5: Goodnight

Little Explorer was very tired now. The adventures had been wonderful, but her eyes were closing and her body felt heavy with sleep.

She lay down in the soft grass of the Star Garden, the little star resting in her hands, and looked up at the sky.

The moon was round and gentle, like a grandmother's smile.

"Goodnight, moon," she whispered.

"Goodnight, fireflies."

"Goodnight, chocolate river and Pillow Mountain."

"Goodnight, owl."

"Goodnight, stars — all the ones that are and all the ones that will be born from my dreams tonight."

And as she closed her eyes, the Star Garden glowed a little brighter, and the fireflies danced a little softer, and the chocolate river hummed a lullaby just for her.

Little Explorer smiled and drifted off to sleep, ready for tomorrow's adventures.

Goodnight, little explorer. Goodnight.

What We Learned

- Imagination can take us on wonderful adventures, even at bedtime.
- Nature is beautiful, especially in the quiet moments.
- Dreams are a special kind of adventure.
- Ending the day with gratitude and peaceful thoughts helps us rest.

Discussion Questions

1. What adventure would you go on before bedtime?
2. What would you say goodnight to if you could say goodnight to everything?
3. How do you feel when someone reads you a bedtime story?

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Thank you for reading!

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